

◀ Methods of execution

In England, condemned witches were often hanged rather than burned. This print shows three women who were hanged at Chelmsford in 1589, among them Joan Cunny, condemned on the evidence of her 10-year-old grandchild, while a fourth sits with their familiars—animal companions.

71 individuals were burned to death in a single day. To help extract confessions, some interrogators used the witch's bridle (an instrument with four iron prongs that pressed into the accused's face), gresions (which crushed their toes), or a strappado (a pulley that jerked their body upward, while weights of up to 440 lb/200 kg dragged at their feet).

England's swimming ordeal

In England, a different method of assessing guilt was favored. "Swimming" involved the hurling of the alleged witch, hands and feet bound together, into a body of water—if she (it was usually a woman) sank she was believed innocent; if she floated she was deemed guilty. It was a technique much used by Matthew Hopkins, the Witch-Finder General, England's most notorious witch hunter.

Hopkins toured eastern England from 1642 to 1644 with his retinue, which included a specialist in finding the witch's teat (a third nipple or a bump on the body)—a mark said to be a sure sign of satanic involvement. His group was responsible for the execution of up to 200 witches, almost half the total number put to death in the country over the entire century of witch persecution.

Spain's *auto-da-fé*

Witch trials devastated entire communities. In Spain's Basque country, in 1609, Inquisitor Juan Valle Alvarado was called in to investigate a coven said to operate from a cave at Zugarramurdi. Eventually 40 people were taken to Logroño for questioning, and 29 were found guilty. Five died in prison. The following year, in an *auto-da-fé* (act of faith), a crowd of over 30,000 watched a procession of the 18 accused who had confessed (and so were forgiven) and the six who had not. Dressed in black, these six walked to stakes where they were burned alive.

Male witches in France

Trials were usually of women, but in Normandy those tried as witches were mostly shepherds, believed to have poisoned their victims with toad venom. Their arrest often took place after the theft of communion wafers from churches. The first to be executed were two shepherds in 1577, and around 100 fell victim in total. The last major trial occurred in 1627. Here, as elsewhere, it was largely the poor or marginalized who paid the price for wider society's preoccupation with witches.



▲ Goya's witch

Spanish artist Goya created a series of paintings inspired by the Zugarramurdi witch trials. Here, an accused sits before the Inquisition tribunal, his status denoted by his large pointed hat.

IN CONTEXT

Modern-day witch hunts

Although witch trials petered out in the 17th century, with the last execution in Europe taking place in Switzerland in 1782, witch hunts have continued into modern times in areas where traditional beliefs have persisted and central authority is weak. In parts of Africa, such as Tanzania, tens of thousands of alleged witches have been persecuted, while in Ghana thousands of women live in camps for those accused of witchcraft—often widows or the elderly, seen as a burden at home. Witch hunts have also risen in Papua New Guinea, and in parts of rural India, where accusations of witchcraft can be used as a pretext to settle scores in divided village communities.



Kukuwo witch camp in Ghana is an enforced home for women accused of witchcraft, many of them vulnerable widows ostracized by their community.